Syllabus Business Projects WT26/27

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Course Synopsis

Business Projects is a capstone-style course designed for students specializing in International Business. The course centers on the development of a comprehensive international marketing plan, requiring students to apply and integrate the knowledge and skills acquired throughout their studies. Each semester, students work on a project that mirrors real-world challenges faced by companies operating across borders.

At the core of the course are marketing and marketing research. Students are expected to investigate international markets systematically, gathering and interpreting data to evaluate opportunities and risks. This involves identifying customer needs, analyzing competitors, and examining cultural, economic, and regulatory environments. Research findings provide the basis for strategic decision-making and for designing a marketing plan that is both realistic and innovative.

The course emphasizes critical thinking, project management, and teamwork in a multicultural context. Students strengthen their ability to translate theory into practice by combining marketing concepts with evidence-based insights. Collaboration, creativity, and structured analysis are essential elements. By the end of the course, students will deliver a structured international marketing plan and demonstrate the ability to use marketing research as a foundation for strategic recommendations—skills directly transferable to careers in international business.

Learning Objectives

The learning objectives of this course combine analytical, methodological, and practical competencies that are essential for careers in international business and marketing. Students will not only deepen their understanding of marketing concepts and research methods but also gain experience in applying them to complex, real-world contexts. By the end of the course, they will have developed both the technical expertise and the soft skills necessary to operate effectively in global environments. In detail, the learning objectives of the course are as follows:

- Design and present a structured international marketing plan based on systematic analysis and research
- Apply marketing concepts in an international context and evaluate opportunities and risks across markets
- Conduct and interpret marketing research to support evidence-based strategic decision-making
- Analyze competition, customer needs, and cultural influences in global business environments
- Strengthening skills in teamwork, project management, and intercultural collaboration
- Communicate complex ideas clearly and persuasively in both written and oral formats
- Develop creativity and problem-solving abilities to propose innovative and feasible strategies
- Integrate analytical, methodological, and practical competencies relevant to international business and marketing

Teaching and Learning Methods

The course follows a flipped classroom approach designed to foster active learning and critical engagement. Students are expected to prepare before class by conducting independent research on key concepts and methods. Classroom time is then dedicated to discussion, application, and peer feedback, ensuring that theoretical insights are directly connected to the project task. This method emphasizes teamwork, self-directed learning, and the practical application of marketing and research tools in an international business context.

Grading

The assessment strategy for this course is designed to reflect the applied and project-based nature of the learning experience. Students are evaluated through a combination of group work and individual contributions, ensuring that both teamwork and personal development are taken into account.

Over the semester, students will deliver three structured presentations. The first is a content presentation (15 minutes) in which students introduce market selection tools, covering their theoretical foundations, real-world applications and pitfalls. This task emphasizes preparation, research, and the ability to explain complex ideas clearly. The second is a mid-term presentation (20 minutes), where each team scores its assigned country on criteria that are common to all groups, analyses the coffee industry in that country and demonstrates how marketing research supports its findings. This stage tests students' analytical abilities and their capacity to translate data into meaningful insights. The third is a final presentation (25 minutes), in which students propose a concrete marketing implementation plan, combining market analysis, strategic reasoning, and marketing recommendations. This capstone presentation highlights their ability to design a coherent, evidence-based international marketing plan.

In addition to group work, each student must submit a **one-page self-reflection** on their learning process, focusing on how they applied marketing and research skills in practice. To encourage accountability and fair collaboration, students also complete a **peer review**, evaluating the engagement and contributions of their group members. This multifaceted assessment ensures that students are recognized for both their collective achievements and their individual growth.

Grades are distributed as follows:

- Group presentation 1: Content presentation – market selection tools (20 %)
- Group presentation 2: Country scoring and industry analysis (30 %)
- Group presentation 3: Marketing implementation plan (30 %)
- Self-Reflection (10 %)
- Peer Review (10 %)

The grading scale is as follows:

- 1 (90-100 %)
- 2 (80-89 %)
- 3 (70-79%)
- 4 (51-69%)
- 5 (0-50%)

Specific Task in the winter term 26/27

As part of this course, students will work on a real-world international business case provided by Julius Meinl, the family-owned Viennese coffee roaster founded in 1862 and now run in its fifth generation. Julius Meinl is present in more than 70 countries, mostly through local distribution partners, both in hospitality (cafés, restaurants and hotels, HoReCa) and in grocery retail. As the company has no own sales organisation in export markets, success depends heavily on the local partner and on how well the brand is positioned in the respective market.

Julius Meinl regards Latin America, covering both South America and Mexico, as a potential future growth region, where it is currently not present or only marginally. The guiding question is therefore which Latin American markets are attractive for Julius Meinl, how market entry could look, and how the brand should be marketed. At the heart of the project lies one critical question: several Latin American countries grow and roast their own coffee and have a strong coffee culture. Why should cafés, hotels, retailers and consumers in such a country choose a coffee brand from Vienna, and who exactly would do so? A convincing market entry and marketing plan must answer this question.

1. **Content Presentation: Market Selection Tools**
   Before analyzing specific markets, each group reviews the tools companies use to screen, compare and select international markets. The presentation covers:
   - The theory behind market selection tools (e.g., scoring and weighting models, market attractiveness–competitive strength portfolios, clustering, distance frameworks)
   - Real-world applications showing how companies actually use these tools
   - Typical pitfalls, such as data availability, subjective weighting or outdated indicators

   Each group concludes by recommending the tool it considers most suitable for comparing Latin American markets for Julius Meinl. In the midterm presentation all groups work with one common scoring model.

2. **Midterm Presentation: Country Scoring and Industry Analysis**
   Part A: Scoring method
   All groups score the same six countries, selected together with Julius Meinl: Argentina, Brazil, Chile, Colombia, Mexico and Uruguay. Each group is allocated one country (Group 1: Argentina, Group 2: Chile, Group 3: Mexico, Group 4: Colombia, Group 5: Uruguay, Group 6: Brazil). The scoring is organised along the six PESTEL dimensions. First, each group searches for 45 criteria (5 political, 10 economic, 10 social, 10 technological, 5 environmental, 5 legal) with a source for each, by session 3 on Monday 19 October 2026. The instructor merges the proposals of all groups and selects the common criteria. The weights of the dimensions are fixed upfront by the instructor. Each group then enters only the numbers of its own country in a shared Google Sheet, which normalises the data and calculates scores and ranks automatically. The dimensions are:
   - Political: stability, governance and trade policy
   - Economic: size, growth, purchasing power and trade conditions
   - Social: demographics, consumption habits, coffee culture and tourism
   - Technological: digital and logistics infrastructure, how people shop and pay
   - Environmental: climate, sustainability expectations and supply risks
   - Legal: rules for importing and selling, regulation and its enforcement

   Groups are expected to:
   - Enter the numbers of the allocated country in the shared Google Sheet, with the year and a source link for every value
   - Interpret the scores by PESTEL dimension and the rank of the country among the six, and give a justified recommendation for the allocated country
   - Explicitly discuss the robustness of the result using the alternative weight sets provided

Part B: Industry analysis (statistics)
Each group searches for information and statistics on the coffee industry in its allocated country and presents them. All numbers are presented in the slides, and a source list documents every source. Students should report the key figures for:

- Hotels: number and category, international chains, guests, food and beverage spending
- Restaurants: number, chains versus independents, sales, growth, coffee prices
- Cafes: number and specialty cafes, chains versus independents, sales, growth, prices of espresso and cappuccino
- Private end customers: consumption per capita, spending, who buys premium coffee, buying habits
- Value chain, import conditions and regulation, trends and outlook

In addition to desk research, students are encouraged to scan the market online, for example menus and prices of premium cafés and restaurants, online reviews and which coffee brands hotels offer. This gives evidence for the industry structure and can be carried out entirely from Vienna.

3. **Final Presentation: Marketing Implementation Plan**
   Each group concludes with a market entry and marketing plan for its assigned market. The plan describes not only how the brand is marketed, but also how Julius Meinl enters the market. It covers:
   - Target segment and first customers
   - Positioning, including an answer to the central question above
   - Price positioning relative to the competition
   - Distribution via a local partner, including a profile of what a suitable partner would look like
   - Communication and in-market activation (including the creative implementation)
   - Rough timeline for market entry, KPIs for the first year and the key risks

Data Sources and Framework Conditions
The project is based on publicly available data. Julius Meinl does not provide internal figures such as revenues, margins, prices or partner names, and these are not required. Possible sources include the coffee country reports of the US Department of Agriculture (USDA), trade statistics on coffee imports, national tourism statistics, and publicly available company material from Julius Meinl such as the corporate story, the sustainability report and the website. If students contact companies or individuals for their research, they do so as students working on a university project and not on behalf of Julius Meinl.

Teaching Schedule

Session	Topic	Student Task
1, 5 Oct	Course Content & Logistics	Prepare Content Presentation
2, 12 Oct	Content Presentation	Find 45 PESTEL Criteria (due session 3)
3, 19 Oct	Coaching Session (Zoom, 20 min per group)	Collect Data (Country Scoring Model)
4, 9 Nov	Coaching Session (Zoom, 20 min per group)	Prepare Midterm Presentation
5, 16 Nov	Mid-Term Presentation (08:00-11:00, TC.5.04)	Marketing Plan for the Assigned Country
6, 23 Nov	Coaching Session, Progress Report	Refinement and Revision
7, 30 Nov	Coaching Session, Progress Report	Prepare Final Presentation
8, 7 Dec	Final Presentation	Self-Reflection, Peer Review

Additional Information for Content Presentation

Your first presentation (Monday 12 October 2026) focuses on market selection tools. Working in teams, you will research and summarize the most relevant approaches used to screen, compare and select international markets (e.g., scoring and weighting models, market attractiveness–competitive strength portfolios, clustering, or distance frameworks). Your task is to cover three aspects: (1) the theory behind the tools, (2) real-world applications showing how companies actually use them, and (3) typical pitfalls such as data availability, subjective weighting, or outdated indicators. Highlight advantages and limitations, and decide which tool you consider most suitable for comparing Latin American markets for Julius Meinl. Be sure to explain and justify your choice clearly. The presentation should not exceed 15 minutes and must be limited to 15 slides. Slides should be information-rich and include clear visualizations, charts, or tables wherever possible to support your arguments. All sources used must be documented in detail in a separate Excel sheet, which will be submitted alongside your presentation. Your goal is not only to demonstrate knowledge of existing models but also to critically evaluate them and communicate your reasoning in a structured way.

Additional Information for Midterm Presentation

For the midterm presentation on Monday 16 November 2026, each group is required to submit one Excel file and one presentation file. The Excel file should contain your country's data with all sources including links, the source list of your industry analysis (every number on your industry slides) and a list of the AI tools you used. The presentation covers the scoring of your allocated country and the industry analysis of that country, and should end with a clear, justified recommendation. The presentation should not exceed 20 minutes (20 slides plus appendix), followed by 10 minutes of discussion. Both files are due on Canvas on Monday 16 November 2026 at 8:00. The midterm is assessed on fit to the case, Part A (scoring method),

Part B (industry analysis), insights and recommendation, presentation, and the industry analysis sources.

Final Presentation
The final presentation takes place on Monday 7 December 2026 (08:00-11:00, TC.5.04) and should last no longer than 25 minutes and provide a clear summary of both the process and the outcomes of your project. Focus on presenting your marketing implementation plan for Julius Meinl, including a concrete set of communication measures (Do not forget the creative implementation).

The Use of AI
You are explicitly encouraged to use (Generative) AI tools. Please make sure that you tell a rich story when you do your presentations. Be honest and list all tools which you have used. You will be graded on the quality, innovativeness and variety of your sources.

Self-reflection
Students need to write one page answering the following questions: 1) What have you learned? 2) What did you like? And 3) What can be improved? Submissions are made via Canvas until one week after the last session (Monday 14 December 2026).

Peer Review
Students need to review the engagement and performance of their group mates based on the following form. Submissions are made via Canvas until one week after the last session (Monday 14 December 2026).

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Peer Rating Form

Each group member is required to submit a peer rating form. This form must contain an evaluation (i.e. a grade) of each group member. Do not assign yourself a grade as this would defeat the idea of peer rating. **The form will be kept in strict confidence**.

In the spaces provided below, please fill in your name, choose your group, and write complete names of all of your group members. Finally, assign a grade on a scale from 0 to 10 to each of your group members (**10 being the highest** and 0 being the lowest grade). Please assign grades based on the following criteria:

- Willingness to carry out assigned tasks
- Ability to meet deadlines
- Quality of the individual's work
- Communication ability and respectful treatment of others
- Availability for and attendance at group meetings
- Following the pre-agreed rules

Your Name:

Your Group:

Group Member Names	Grade
1. Group Member Name	Insert grade
2. Group Member Name	Insert grade
3. Group Member Name	Insert grade
4. Group Member Name	Insert grade
5. Group Member Name	Insert grade

(Optional) Additional Comments